

Session 34: The Armor of God

Key Takeaways

- Paul wants his communities to know that their real enemy is not other humans. Their enemy is the larger social, economic, political, and religious forces animated by the powers that govern and shape human existence.
- The new humanity is a corporate entity made of people who need to be shaped by the Spirit for a new kind of relationship.
- Paul tells us to put on God's own armor, the divine attributes that God himself used to confront the powers of evil.
- In Ephesians 6, Paul borrows from Isaiah 11, 52, 53, and 59 as he talks about the armor we all wear as the body of Jesus.

The Struggle To Live as God's Family: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 6:10-20

¹⁰ Finally, find strength in the Lord
and in the power of his might.
¹¹ Put on the full armor of God,
so that y'all have power to stand
against the schemes of the slanderer,
¹² because our battle is not against flesh and blood,
but against the rulers,
against the authorities,
against the cosmic-powers of this darkness,
against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenlies.
¹³ Because of this,
take up the armor of God,
so that y'all have power to stand in resistance
on the day of evil,
and having fulfilled one's duty,
to stand.
¹⁴ Stand, therefore,
having girded y'all's loins with truth,
and having put on the breastplate of justice,
¹⁵ and having tied y'all's feet with the good news of peace,
¹⁶ in all situations having taken up the shield of faith,
by which y'all have power to extinguish the flaming arrows of the evil one.
¹⁷ And take the helmet of salvation,
and the Spirit's sword,
which is the word of God.
¹⁸ With every prayer and petition,
praying on every occasion in the Spirit,
and for this reason staying alert
with all endurance
and petition
for all of the holy ones,
¹⁹ and for me,
so that a word would be given to me
when I open my mouth,
to make known with boldness
the open-secret of the good news,
²⁰ on behalf of which
I am an ambassador
in chains,
so that by it I might be bold as I am obligated to speak.

Ephesians 6:10-20. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

The Role of Ephesians 6:10-20 Within the Flow of 4:1-6:2

“There is one further important point to make about this passage. It is very easy to read this discussion of the armor of God and then to assume that this is a set of instructions to individual believers to take up the armor of God. That is not the way the text reads. Rather, the command to take up the armor of God is a summons to the community as a whole. Taking up the armor of God is a communal practice integrally tied to the unity of the church and the church’s witness to the powers (3:10). In this respect, 6:10–20 continues the emphasis on the common life of the church that began in 4:1.”

Fowl, Stephen E. (2012). [*Ephesians: A Commentary \(The New Testament Library\)*](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 200–201.

The Spiritual Conflict

Paul assumes that the unity of the messianic community will be threatened by the powers.

Paul wants his communities to know that their real enemy is never another human but the larger social, economic, political, and religious forces that govern and shape human existence. Paul, along with all Jews shaped by the biblical traditions, viewed these forces as manifestations of spiritual rulers, authorities, etc., who are opposed to the cosmic reign of the Messiah.

Kosmokratoras (Greek: *κοσμοκράτωρ*) in Ephesians 6:12 comes from “world, cosmos” (*kosmo-*) and “grab, hold” (*krator*). By this Paul refers to the ordering structures of a society.

“[W]hat Paul means by principalities and powers are those institutions and structures by which earthly matters and invisible realms are administered, and without which no human life is possible. The superior power of nature epitomized by the cycles of life and death; the ups and downs of historic processes; what a culture holds up as the ideal or the sub-human ... the power of capitalists, rulers, judges; the benefit and onus of laws of tradition and custom; political and religious practices; the weight of ideologies and prejudices; the conditions under which all authority, labor, parenthood, etc., thrive or are crushed—these structures and institutions are in Paul’s mind ... God’s creation does not consist of earthly-visible things alone. Just as Genesis 1:1 addresses the creation of the heavens and the earth, so also in Colossians 1:16 Paul speaks of ‘invisible powers in heavens and on earth.’ It is probable that in Ephesians Paul had in mind at the same time both visible, specific governors and the invisible authority exerted by them; concrete conditions and manifestations of life and the invisible mystery of the collective human psyche; specific laws and the overarching role of law in a culture, etc. According to Ephesians 1:10, both the heavenly and the earthly entities are subjected to Christ. Only when both are affected is the whole creation changed.”

Adapted from Barth, Markus (1974). [*Ephesians 1-3*](#). Doubleday & Co. 174-175.

Paul wants church communities to know that the “schemes of the slanderer” (Eph. 6:11) will be aimed precisely at the unity and mutual interdependence of the new humanity (recall the schemes of Eph. 4:14; see also 2 Cor. 2:11). Such schemes will always be large-scale and difficult to identify.

Present-day examples:

- Rampant individualism
- Patriarchalism and male supremacy
- Sexual “liberation”
- Western (democratic and capitalist) supremacy

- Digital consumerism (built on economic exploitation)
- Racism
- Self-actualization through radical individualism
- Digital hierarchies of social worth (a.k.a. Instagram and Facebook)
- Political factionalism

The Divine Armor

Paul has used the imagery of putting on armor in two other letters, and the parallels are illuminating.

- Romans 13:11-14: In light of the dawning of the age of new creation (“the day is near”), Jesus’ people are to “take off” the life-habits of the old age and to put on something new. “Putting on” the armor of the new age is synonymous with “putting on the Messiah,” a baptismal image familiar elsewhere in Paul’s writings (Gal. 3:27 “for as many as are baptized into Messiah, they have put on the Messiah;” see also Eph. 4:24; Col. 3:10).
- 1 Thessalonians 5:8-9: In light of the dawning of the new age, Jesus’ people are to stay awake as “sons of light” and put on the armor of God’s attributes.

Paul’s reference in Ephesians 6:10 develops these images from his earlier letters and explicitly links them to the divine armor of the messianic king in Isaiah, which was further elaborated in the Wisdom of Solomon.

Isaiah 59:16-17 NIV

¹⁶ He saw that there was no one, he was appalled that there was no one to intervene;
so his own arm achieved salvation for him, and his own righteousness sustained him.

¹⁷ He put on righteousness as his breastplate, and the helmet of salvation on his head;
he put on the garments of vengeance and wrapped himself in zeal as in a cloak.

Isaiah 11:5 NASB

Also righteousness will be the belt about his loins,
and faithfulness the belt about his waist.

Isaiah 49:2 NASB

[Yahweh] has made my mouth like a sharp sword

Isaiah 52:7 NASB*

How lovely on the mountains
are the feet of the one bringing good news,
announcing peace ...
announcing salvation ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Wisdom of Solomon 5:16-20 NRSV

¹⁶ Therefore they will receive a glorious crown
and a beautiful diadem from the hand of the Lord,
because with his right hand he will cover them,

and with his arm he will shield them.

¹⁷ The Lord will take his zeal as his whole armor,
and will arm all creation to repel his enemies;

¹⁸ he will put on righteousness as a breastplate,
and wear impartial justice as a helmet;

¹⁹ he will take holiness as an invincible shield,

²⁰ and sharpen stern wrath for a sword,
and creation will join with him to fight against his frenzied foes.

1 Thessalonians 5:8 NASB

But since we are of the day, let us be sober, having put on the breastplate of faith and love, and as a helmet, the hope of salvation.

Ephesians 6:14-17 NASB*

¹⁴ Stand firm therefore, having girded your loins with truth, and having put on the breastplate of righteousness, ¹⁵ and having put shoes your feet with the preparation of the gospel of peace; ¹⁶ in addition to all, taking up the shield of faith with which you will be able to extinguish all the flaming arrows of the evil one. ¹⁷ And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“The allusions made to OT passages show that all these weapons are used and tested by God himself, and that they are first entrusted to one person on earth: the Messiah. [Isaiah 11:2-5](#) avers that through the Spirit, or together with the Spirit, a special armament is given to God’s Anointed One: the (sword of) the word and the girdle of righteousness. Ephesians 6 goes beyond the OT: through the mediation of the Messiah and the Spirit, God’s weapons are now transferred to all the saints. The logic of the argument is this: if these arms are spiritual, and if they are sufficient for God and Jesus Christ—they will certainly be good enough for the saints.”

Barth, Markus (1974). [Ephesians 4-6](#). Anchor Bible. 784.

“If we recall Paul’s depiction of the church as the ‘body of Christ’ ([Eph. 1:23](#)) and the new temple of God’s presence here on earth ([Eph. 2:20](#)), it makes perfect sense that here Paul describes the community as the embodiment of Isaiah’s divine warrior. Paul is not merely addressing individuals, but their corporate identity as Christ’s body ... Paul does not derive the armor of God by pondering the outfit of a Roman soldier, but by considering the Scriptures ... and he calls the people of God to put on God’s own virtues ... But the enemy in the church’s warfare is not the world, nor people in the world, but ‘the powers.’ Paul subverts his own military metaphor by showing that this ‘war’ is waged by performing Jesus’ humility, self-sacrifice, and weakness.”

Gombis, Timothy G. (2010). [The Drama of Ephesians: Participating in the Triumph of God](#). IVP Academic. 157-159.

Reflection Question

How do you think this section on the armor of God is bringing the whole letter of Ephesians to a culmination?
How does it relate to the message of the whole letter?

Session 35: Reflecting on the Armor of God

Key Takeaways

- The snake is always present when we choose between the old humanity and the new humanity.
- The powers want to persuade us that our real identity, value, and destiny is based on something other than Jesus' death and resurrection, the gift of his Spirit, and our unity as the new humanity. We resist the powers with the true reality of Jesus.
- Truth is not an idea that you need to learn. Truth is a person you must encounter.

Conclusion: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 6:21-24

²¹ So that y'all also might know how things are with me,
what I'm doing,
Tychicus will make everything known to y'all,
that beloved brother
and faithful servant in the Lord,
²² whom I sent to y'all for this reason,
so that y'all might know how things are with us
and that he might comfort y'all's hearts.

²³ Peace to the brothers and sisters,
and love
with faith,
from God the Father
and from Lord Jesus the Messiah.

²⁴ Grace be with all who love our Lord Jesus Messiah
with incorruptible [love].

Ephesians 6:21-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Resources on Ephesians

Commentaries

General and accessible, comments paragraph by paragraph:

- N. T. Wright, [*Paul for Everyone: The Prison Letters: Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon*](#)

More detailed, comments verse by verse in expositional form:

- Ben Witherington III, [*The Letters to Philemon, the Colossians, and the Ephesians: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary on the Captivity Epistles*](#)
- John Stott, [*The Message of Ephesians \(The Bible Speaks Today\)*](#)

Other Books on Ephesians

- Timothy G. Gombis, [*The Drama of Ephesians: Participating in the Triumph of God*](#)

Resources on the Household Code of Ephesians 5

- Cynthia Long Westfall, [*Paul and Gender: Reclaiming the Apostle's Vision for Men and Women in Christ*](#)
- Philip Barton Payne, [*Man and Woman, One in Christ*](#)

Introductions to Paul

- Michael Gorman, [*Apostle of the Crucified Lord: A Theological Introduction to Paul and His Letters*](#)
- Timothy G. Gombis, [*Paul: A Guide for the Perplexed*](#)
- N. T. Wright, [*Paul: A Biography*](#)
- E. Randolph Richards, [*Paul and First-Century Letter Writing: Secretaries, Composition, and Collection*](#)

Reflection Question

Read the last four verses of the letter to the Ephesians ([Eph. 6:21-24](#)). Now that you've reached the end of the letter and the class, how would you summarize the main idea of the book of Ephesians? Try to keep it to just a few sentences.